

Director of the Agency, Zdravko Vukić, participated in a panel at the III International Congress of Lawyers, which is being held from February 27 to March 2 in Bled, Slovenia.

The panel discussion on the protection of personal data in neighboring countries brought together directors of personal data protection agencies from Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Serbia. On this occasion, Director Vukić presented the powers that the Agency holds and how procedures are conducted that may result in administrative monetary fines. He emphasized that last year, the Agency for Personal Data Protection (AZOP) issued the highest number of administrative monetary fines to date, totaling 28, amounting to 8.27 million euros, and that among them is the largest fine in the history of the Agency, amounting to 5.47 million euros for serious violations of the Regulation.

When it comes to the biggest challenges, the director listed several, including insufficient awareness among citizens and data controllers regarding personal data protection in the Republic of Croatia. For this reason, the Agency devotes significant attention to activities aimed at raising awareness about the importance of personal data protection, through the implementation of projects and numerous educational activities. "Certain challenges exist in the interaction of the GDPR with other laws, such as the Directive on e-Privacy, and there is much discussion about artificial intelligence and the processing of personal data within such systems. We believe that we will be responsible for the upcoming Act on Artificial Intelligence, and these are challenges that need to be considered in advance," said Director Vukić.

In conclusion, he also reflected on the processing of biometric data, which is more specifically regulated in the Republic of Croatia by the Law on the Implementation of the General Data Protection Regulation. "This is a technology that poses risks to the right to personal data protection, but also to other values of a democratic society. As a democratic society, it is essential that we ensure there is no mass surveillance of our citizens under the guise of security. We have seen examples of the misuse of cameras that use facial recognition technology, for instance in China, where mass surveillance of citizens is conducted in terms of controlling their behavior," emphasized Zdravko Vukić, concluding that organizations that have a legal basis to process biometric data must thoroughly and appropriately consider the security of such processing.

The organizers of the Congress – KEC Group, as well as the panelists, congratulated Director Zdravko Vukić on his reappointment as the director of AZOP, wishing him continued success in his work for the next four years.

Incidentally, the GDPR is the main theme of this year's Congress, where numerous data protection experts have gathered to provide participants with insights into the application of the General Data Protection Regulation in various sectors and to answer all the uncertainties they have in their business regarding the protection of personal data.